

Session 17 DM Guide

The missed delivery and the council map

Run a substantial investigation that earns the party a voice in Greenest's defense. Start at the chalk cut, play the camp, recover and interpret evidence, then let the players set the operation. Stop before resolving that operation.

Four arcs with a decision ending

- Arc 1 • Missed delivery • 20–25 minutes. Mara, Doss, the plate and a route into the camp.
- Arc 2 • A playable camp • 35–45 minutes. Scout, enter, make contacts and manage suspicion.
- Arc 3 • Evidence and the map puzzle • 35–45 minutes. Reconstruct three coordinated enemy assignments from three clues.
- Arc 4 • The party takes command • 40–50 minutes. Return by their chosen route, present evidence, debate deployments and record orders.

Allow 15–20 minutes for recap and a break: roughly 2½–3 hours. These are pacing estimates, never reasons to delay a solved scene. If camp play expands, finish the council at the start of next session rather than skipping player choices.

Opening and continuity

Dawn, north-road chalk cut; Throk holds the brass control plate. The paper says before dawn. No automatic rest, refill, level-up or hallucination penalty. Confirm resources at the table; all five remain level 2. The mill rescue succeeded, the old arch stays sealed, and the plate test revealed a physically broken channel.

What is new in this revision

The camp layout, three-part operation, local route details and council resource allotment are unplayed session prep. They do not establish events, permanent geography or a successful attack. Nighthill's willingness to delegate and Escobert's respect for practical expertise are established DM background. Earn their confidence through evidence and a workable plan.

Prepare these materials

- Show the existing chalk-cut intro and tactical map. Keep the existing payment slip concealed until earned.
- Use Session17_Camp_Map.png for navigation. Give Sev Session17_Strategy_Map.png when the party obtains or copies the survey map.
- Cut or separately reveal the three player clue cards. The DM solution and council record stay private.

Guardrails

No forced plate surrender, camp assault, civilian evacuation or military appointment. No identity answer for the dragon, departure omen, Pat's ancestry or Floyd's divine source. The dragon flyover is a brief mid-session event; it never ends the adventure by itself.

Current main-branch sources: 00, CHATGPT_PROJECT_INSTRUCTIONS, 01, 02, 03, 04, 07, 09, 10 and 11 in sstudham/dnd-campaign. Revision follows Scott's direction to make the camp playable and end with strategic decisions.

Arc 1 The missed delivery

Start on the road at the chalk cut • Do not begin in town

Opening read aloud

Dawn turns the chalk walls white. Fresh wagon tracks lead around the bend. Someone shouts, "Stop pulling. You're making it worse." A half-loaded mule cart stands beside a fresh collapse. One young man is pinned beneath stone and broken timber. A woman looks from you to the brass in Throk's hands. "You're late."

Run the meeting

Mara Venn is a paid intermediary for Frulam Mondath's network. She wants the plate intact, Doss alive and her route protected. Doss Fen is hired labor, not a fanatic. The single guard prioritizes Doss. A messenger has already ridden north because the delivery missed its deadline.

Keep the rescue short. Floyd freely recognizes that the upper chalk must be braced or pressure relieved beside Doss's leg. A credible careful solution works. Use DC 9 with help or DC 11 for rushed uncertain execution; a setback costs time, cart load or minor injury, not an arbitrary death. Do not repeat the full mill rescue.

After help, Mara says: "You could have left him. I noticed. Now tell me whether we are doing business."

Information that opens the adventure

- Mara recognizes the exact plate. Frulam's people ordered it intact and untested. Doss overheard: "The dragon gets the key; the town gets left alone."
- A northern camp coordinates the work. The map and records there may explain what was removed and what they intend next. Mara knows logistics, not the vault's complete purpose.
- The payment slip offers 40 gp, initials F.M., transfer north, and "Hold for L." Initials alone do not identify the dragon.

Let their approach create access

Help and bargain: Mara can introduce them as late contractors asking to settle the delivery. Bluff: the work order and a plausible answer to "Who told you not to turn the channels?" support a courier cover. Observe or refuse: rider tracks, wagon tracks, Doss or the route sketch provide an independent way north. No exact password and no clue gated behind one roll.

Keeping the plate is valid. Mara may escort them to negotiate without obtaining it. Surrendering it is also valid; honor the 40 gp payment if they pass as couriers and track its custody. Following a cart must not become an offscreen theft.

If they choose violence or withdrawal

Only Mara and the guard fight; Doss does not. Reuse S16 Hired Raider: AC 12, HP 9, speed 30, club +3, 1d4+1. They surrender or withdraw. Captured papers or survivors retain the camp lead. Do not add a surprise wave.

If they withdraw toward town, honor it. The work order and witness can still prompt reconnaissance; a willing local scout can bring incomplete camp evidence. Do not move the whole camp encounter onto the road or pretend they visited it.

Transition

Beyond the chalk hills, cooking smoke hangs low over a shallow valley. Wagons stand among tents. Some people carry weapons; others carry tools. This is where the work was organized. You have time to watch before deciding how to enter.

Arc 2 The camp is a place to play

Use the camp map • Offer visible routes before asking for checks

Six connected locations

- A Delivery entrance: a clerk asks who sent them and what they carry. A work order, Mara's introduction or a credible cover opens conversation; surrendering the plate is not the entrance fee.
- B Wagon yard: empty wagons, drums and six shields are being issued together. A dispatch copy provides clue A. The clerk wants loads counted and interruptions ended.
- C Workers quarters: an unnamed survey assistant wants safe passage home. They helped measure the mill approach and now regret it. Practical concern earns clue B; threats get guarded answers, not deleted information.
- D Survey and records tent: Sev spots a large, carefully annotated regional map. A bored records keeper permits supervised contractor inspection; copying, bargaining, distraction or theft are other routes. This is not Frulam's personal tent.
- E Signal and stores yard: shuttered lanterns and covered tools. An issue slip supplies clue C. The equipment keeper fears blame for missing stock and will trade information for a credible receipt.
- F Watch post: two guards, an alarm bell and a view of the main entrance. They question suspicious activity; they do not magically know who stole a paper.

Three approaches with distinct strengths

Courier cover uses A and B, with access to D through paperwork. Worker cover uses C and earns a guide toward D or E. A stealth approach uses canvas gaps and the western laundry path. Describe sightlines, moving workers and the bell before players take risks. The camp is not one Stealth check.

Suspicion follows observable actions

Track 0–3: 0 normal business; 1 questions and an escort; 2 a specific area searched; 3 alarm and exits watched. Advance only for a witnessed intrusion, exposed lie, found theft or violence. Clever explanations can contain suspicion. One failed check creates a complication, not universal recognition.

For uncertain improvised actions, use DC 11 for plausible low-risk work and DC 13 for a watched restricted area. Reward good plans with access or advantage. Talk openly about likely consequences. Current party resources determine whether combat is sensible.

The dragon passes overhead

Conversation thins as the animals pull at their tethers. A vast winged shadow crosses the camp. Faces turn upward. The dragon continues north without landing or speaking. Somewhere, a dropped ladle strikes a pot. For a moment, nobody is watching the records tent.

Use once during camp exploration, not to erase an existing alarm. Give a brief opportunity to reposition or inspect something; do not grant automatic theft. If the plate is present, one vibration is enough. Nothing identifies the dragon or explains Pat's scale.

If a fight happens

Start with the two local watch guards using S16 Hired Raider. Their purpose is to block a route or ring the bell. Show that the wider camp is dangerous before an assault. Escape, bargaining and surrender remain available. A clean infiltration is allowed to stay clean.

Arc 3 Solve the council map

Recover evidence • Hand the map to Sev • Let everyone work on it

The find

Under a stack of payment sheets is a survey of Greenest and its northern approaches. Sev, its notes record where wagons fit, where feet can pass, and which heights command a view. Three symbols repeat: a wheel, a spade and a lantern. Someone has planned movements around the town. The map is useful. The loose papers will tell you what it means.

The regional map is available at D. Reveal A, B and C as the party earns them at B, C and E. Backup copies: D has the dispatch and survey notes; the signal order travels with the messenger. A friendly witness can repeat observed details. Never require a particular theft, living NPC or skill roll for the only copy.

Ask three concrete questions

- Which route does each marked group have to use? Place Wheel, Spade and Lantern on the map.
- What is the loud movement intended to make the town do? Which group has the real local objective?
- What event releases the hidden movement? What could the town change to break that coordination?

DM solution

Wheel = wagon road through the chalk cut. Its empty wagons, shields and drums create a conspicuous threat at the north approach. Lantern = signal ridge; only that site sees both the north approach and the east track. Spade = east drainage track, on foot, to seize the mill service lane after the defenders are drawn north.

Sequence: Wheel makes noise at dusk; Lantern waits until town defenders move north; one long shuttered flash releases Spade. If the defenders stay home, there is no authorized flash. Spade is instructed to hold rather than begin a suicidal attack. This exposes a coordinated feint, not a guaranteed future victory.

Why the puzzle is fair

The map supplies terrain constraints; A supplies the deceptive load; B supplies the physical destination; C supplies the dependency. No cipher vocabulary, unseen lore or check is required. Wrong ideas can be tested against visible evidence. Once they explain routes, purpose and trigger, they have solved it. Do not require DM wording.

Hints, in order: “Could those wagons use that path?” Then “Why send empty wagons with drums?” Finally “Who is supposed to move before the lantern flashes?” A skill check can point to a missed sentence; it cannot replace their strategic choices.

Evidence and trust

Preserve or copy the orders and the map. The survey assistant can corroborate tool marks and routes but is neither compulsory nor automatically innocent. Floyd can distinguish a plausible engineering approach from a claimed magical shortcut. This drainage route reaches the mill exterior; it does not open the sealed arch or repair the vault.

Choose how to leave with what they learned

The party decides whether to slip out, leave under its cover, escort the witness, bargain with Mara or attempt disruption now. Do not impose a second extraction climax. Resolve immediate actions they choose; record changes to enemy awareness and resources for the later council.

Arc 4 Give the orders

Play the return or messenger contact • End with a committed plan

An earned invitation

Offer a return to Greenest with evidence; narrate the chosen journey only after players choose it. They can instead send a messenger and request a field meeting. If they refuse civic involvement, let them plan their own operation without granting authority they declined. Leave enough daylight for the return and discussion; dusk is a disclosed planning deadline, not a surprise punishment for roleplay.

Escobert spreads the recovered map flat. Nighthill listens while you explain the wagons, the tools and the signal. “You have shown us where they mean to put us,” the governor says. “Now show us where we should stand. Escobert, tell them what we can actually spare.”

Resources for the council exercise

Proposed available resources: three small guard teams; two volunteer work crews; one transport team with two carts. These are the forces available for reassignment, not every guard or civilian in Greenest. Background keep and sanctuary care continue. Confirm these prep quantities at the table before debate; do not silently change them afterward.

Each team gets one primary assignment for the opening phase. A later move is possible only with a route, timing and trigger. Volunteers can dig, brace, carry, guide or signal; they are not interchangeable with trained fighters. Patient movement needs care, escorts and a destination. The party chooses its own position and who keeps the plate.

Debate with concrete stakes

- North approach: show a screen, stage a false withdrawal, negotiate, or hold strength back? A large visible response may trigger the enemy plan.
- Mill lane and drainage track: quietly block, observe, ambush, patrol or concede? A barrier costs work and may be discovered; preserve an inspection and escape route.
- Signal ridge: watch, seize, spoof or ignore it? Interference breaks coordination but can alert the camp. Do not promise it ends the wider conflict.
- Keep, temple and west orchard: where do patients, workers and reserves go? Sheltering in place, limited relocation and organized evacuation are all legitimate.

Two workable examples for the DM only

Hold and expose: one guard team screens north; one protects the mill; one stays mobile. A work crew prepares a discreet barrier; the other supports shelter and signals. Carts remain for casualties. Defenders avoid the bait and challenge the exposed raiders.

Protect and intercept: two teams cover the mill route; one escorts a limited civilian relocation. Crews prepare refuge and observation; carts carry those unable to walk. The party watches the ridge or negotiates. This sacrifices some visible road control for people and the actual objective.

Neither is the answer key. Assess novel plans on the same known constraints. A credible explanation and viable assignments earn advisory authority for this operation; no Persuasion roll is needed to make competence count. Lasting leadership depends on outcomes and consent, not an automatic title.

Stop after the decision

Escobert places markers where you have ordered them. “Then these are our positions. What is the signal to act—and what tells us to fall back?”

Fill the decision record. End as orders are confirmed or messengers depart. Do not narrate the operation’s result, an evacuation or the enemy’s response before the players have chosen and we have storyboarded the consequences.

Session ending decision record

Fill from actual play • Blank fields remain unknown

What they know and possess

Map obtained or copied: _____ Clues A / B / C: _____

Witnesses and promises: _____

Plate holder and location: _____

Camp suspicion and evidence enemy has about the party: _____

What the party orders

Primary objective and acceptable cost: _____

Guard team 1 position / task: _____

Guard team 2 position / task: _____

Guard team 3 position / task: _____

Work crew 1 and 2: _____

Two carts / escorts / care / destination: _____

Party position and any split: _____

Signal / timing / who may give it: _____

Fallback trigger and route: _____

Orders kept secret / enemy deception / negotiation terms: _____

After play storyboard with Scott

Use the annotated map and actual orders to build 4–6 opening beats. For each: location; friendly intent; what opponents actually know; enemy response; warning the players can perceive; immediate choice; unresolved roll or uncertainty. Distinguish a prediction from a settled event.

- First frame: show a visible consequence of one real player decision—a guarded lane, prepared refuge or occupied ridge.
- Second frame: show the enemy move supported by its orders and current knowledge. Do not give opponents knowledge of a secret plan for dramatic convenience.
- Third frame: let the two plans meet. Competent preparation should change position, timing or available choices.
- Fourth frame: introduce a complication grounded in an accepted risk, not a random reversal designed to cancel success.
- Final frame: return control at the first unresolved decision or contested action. Resolve danger in play; do not pre-decide casualties, betrayal or victory between sessions.

Record before leaving the table

Current HP, spent resources, secured rests, witnesses, promises, payments and exact enemy contact. Photograph or save the marked map. Quote the final orders back to the players and resolve contradictory instructions now.

No report of play is saved to canon without Scott's explicit save instruction. Unused scenes remain preparation.